

Day 2 — Defining the North Star Metric

Activity packet for participant triads. Today's job: take yesterday's NS placeholder and stress-test it into a North Star you can defend in front of a CEO and a dispatcher in the same conversation.

Where we are in the week

Day 1 produced a Metrics Tier Sheet with a placeholder NS. Today we replace the placeholder with a defensible NS — and along the way, the cohort encounters the **three standard pitfalls** that catch even seasoned PMs.

By 16:00, every triad will have:

- A **North Star statement** that names the customer outcome, the segment, and the measurement
- A **defense card** that names the three pitfalls applied to their own NS and rebuts each
- A **revised Metrics Tier Sheet** with the placeholder replaced

The three standard pitfalls (today's mental model)

PITFALL	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	THE TELL
1. Vanity dressed up	"Total active users" or "ARR" — sounds north-star-ish, isn't	Customers don't feel it directly when this number moves
2. Leading-indicator confusion	"Time-to-first-value" — actually a KPI or even op-signal	A team can move it without the customer being any better off long-term
3. Gameable target	"Daily Active Users" with no usage-quality gate	A team can hit the target with sales tactics or notification spam

Every well-formed NS has been challenged against all three and survived.

Activity 1 — Three Pitfalls Triage

Format: Triad • 35 min • Block 1

Purpose

Recognize the three pitfalls in real-world examples before applying them to your own NS — pattern-recognition before self-diagnosis.

Setup

Each triad has the example pack of 8 anonymized public-company NS candidates.

Steps

The example pack (8 NS candidates from public companies, anonymized)

1. "Monthly Active Riders" — ride-share co.
2. "Total Bookings Volume" — hospitality marketplace
3. "Hours Watched per Day" — streaming service
4. "Songs Saved to Library" — music streaming
5. "Daily Active Users" — social network
6. "Annual Recurring Revenue" — vertical SaaS
7. "Successful Deliveries per Active Customer per Month" — logistics SaaS (Expeditors-adjacent)
8. "Queries Resolved without Human Escalation" — customer support SaaS

Triad protocol

For each card, the triad assigns **0, 1, 2, or 3** pitfalls present and writes a 1-line argument.

Readout (60 seconds per triad)

"We give [X] a clean bill of health because [reason]. We give [Y] all three pitfalls because [reason]."

Deliverable

A scored card pack per triad: each card tagged with 0–3 pitfalls and a one-line argument; one clean-bill-of-health pick and one all-three pick identified.

Activity 2 — Re-write Your NS

Format: Triad • 40 min • Block 2

Purpose

Apply yesterday's placeholder + today's pitfalls to draft a defensible NS for the triad's Week-1 problem.

Setup

Each triad has its Day-1 NS placeholder visible, plus the Day-2 three-pitfalls vocabulary fresh from Activity 1.

Steps

Triad protocol

1. **Read your placeholder NS aloud** (each triad member, then a 2-minute discussion of dissatisfaction).
2. **Generate three NS candidates** (15 min). Each member proposes one. They must:
 - Name a customer outcome (verb-based, not feature-based)
 - Specify a user segment narrowly
 - Be expressible as a single number
3. **Pitfall-test each candidate** (15 min). For each: which of the three pitfalls is closest to true? Can you rebut?
4. **Converge on one** (10 min). The winner gets written into the **NS Defense Card** template (below).

NS Defense Card template

North Star

We are winning when [outcome] increases for [segment], measured by [number].

Pitfall rebuttals

- **Vanity:** Why does this number changing mean a customer's life got better?
> [your answer in <30 words]
- **Leading-indicator:** Could a team move this without the customer being meaningfully better off?
> [your answer]
- **Gameable:** What's the most cynical way a team could hit this without earning it?
> [your answer + the guardrail you'd add]

Counter-metric (the guardrail)

A second metric that, if it moves *the wrong way*, signals we're winning the NS for the wrong reasons.
> [counter-metric]

The **counter-metric** concept is new today. Examples:

- NS = "Hours of returned dispatcher time" → Counter = "% of dispatchers calling support after the new flow"
- NS = "Tickets resolved without escalation" → Counter = "Rate of repeated tickets from the same customer"

Deliverable

A completed NS Defense Card per triad: NS statement, three pitfall rebuttals, and a named counter-metric.

Activity 3 — The "CEO and Dispatcher" Test

Format: Triad pairs • 40 min • Block 3

Purpose

A defensible NS sounds right to two audiences at once. Today we rehearse.

Setup

Triads pair off. Each triad has its NS Defense Card from Activity 2 and the two persona scripts below.

Steps

Each triad takes turns being the **defender** and the **challenger**.

- Challenger plays **CEO** for 4 minutes: probe whether the NS will move the company forward, scale, and survive a board review.
- Challenger plays **Dispatcher (target customer)** for 4 minutes: probe whether the NS reflects something they would actually feel.
- Defender records the strongest challenge from each role.

The two persona scripts (challengers can extend or paraphrase)

CEO Maria (FieldPulse):

"I have eight squads competing for engineering budget. Sell me on why your NS is the one I should care about for the next 12 months. What if it goes up 20%? What does that earn the company?"

Dispatcher Maria (FieldPulse):

"Look — I've used four of these apps. I don't care about your charts. Tell me what changes about my Wednesday afternoon if you hit your number."

After the round

Each triad updates its NS Defense Card with:

- The CEO's strongest challenge + how the triad would address it
- The dispatcher's strongest challenge + how the triad would address it

If the NS doesn't survive both — that's the artifact for tomorrow's coaching, not a failure.

Deliverable

An updated NS Defense Card with two new lines: the CEO's strongest challenge + response, and the dispatcher's strongest challenge + response.

Activity 4 — NS Lock-in + Tier Sheet Refresh

Format: Triad • 45 min + Readouts • Block 4

Purpose

Replace yesterday's placeholder, walk the new NS up and down the Tier Sheet to confirm coherence, and present.

Setup

Each triad has its NS Defense Card (updated through Activity 3) and Day-1 Tier Sheet visible.

Steps

Triad workflow

1. **Lock in the NS** (10 min). Confirm wording. Confirm the counter-metric. Confirm the NS rebuttal answers.
2. **Walk it down** (15 min). Re-examine the operational signals from yesterday — does each one *plausibly* contribute to this NS? Drop or replace any that don't.
3. **Walk it up** (5 min). Does the NS roll up clearly to a business outcome that leadership cares about?
4. **Polish** (15 min). Final Tier Sheet, final Defense Card. Both shareable.

Readout structure (90 seconds per triad)

1. "Our NS is [X], measured by [Y], for [segment]."
2. "The strongest challenge it survived was [Z]."
3. "Our counter-metric is [counter] — if that moves wrong, we know we're cheating."

Deliverable

A locked NS + counter-metric, a refreshed Tier Sheet with the placeholder replaced, and a 90-second readout ready to deliver.

End-of-day checkpoint

Each triad leaves the day with:

- ✓ A locked-in **North Star** with explicit pitfall rebuttals
- ✓ A **counter-metric** that guards against gameability
- ✓ A **revised Metrics Tier Sheet** (placeholder replaced)
- ✓ A Day 3 commitment: bring one product surface (FieldPulse mobile or web) you want to UX-audit tomorrow